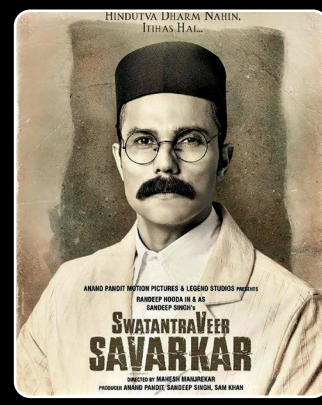
to prioritise informing, and not just entertaining, the audience. March 15 sees the release of filmmaker Sudipto Sen and producer Vipul Amrutlal Shah's latest collaboration, this time for *Bastar: The Naxal Story*, a story about the Naxals residing in the Chhattisgarh district and the "lobbies" supporting them in cities, as per Shah. The long-gestating biopic of Veer Savarkar finally arrives in theatres in March, followed by *The Sabarmati Report*, about the fire that engulfed the state of Gujarat in 2002. And Kangana Ranaut is saving her political drama, *Emergency*, for after the general election.

The line-up represents a trend in which Hindi filmmakers are eager to take up hard-hitting issues even if they may face accusations of toeing a political line or have their films banned in Gulf countries, as *Article 370* was. That these agenda-laden narratives arrive months before the Lok Sabha election and in some cases show the ruling dispensation in a positive light shows a film industry that's eager to appease the political masters.

For Jambhale, what was missing so far in the growing stockpile of films "inspired by true events" was a "proper political thriller" in the realm of *Zero Dark Thirty* (2012), the Oscar-nominated Hollywood drama that tracks the behind-the-scenes workings of the team that eventually captured Osama bin Laden. The complexities in the plot were not a deterrent for Jambhale; the research only convinced him to pursue the film. "My whole intention was that when a fifth standard student, who perhaps doesn't love history and politics, will go to theatre and watch it, he should know whatever he needs to know on how Article 370 was abrogated and narrate it, because he understood it," says Jambhale. The other aim, he adds, was to make "aspirational and cool" heroes out of NIA agents and bureaucrats.

CALL IT THEIR CINEMA VÉRITÉ

A biopic of Savarkar, Indira Gandhi during Emergency or Godhra—soon to be released films are going where others feared to tread in the past



SWATANTRA VEER SAVARKAR

"I don't hate Gandhi. I hate non-violence," declares Randeep Hooda's Savarkar. Also the film's director and co-producer, Hooda looks to settle the debate with a biopic around a divisive leader. ***Release date: March 22***

THE SABARMATI REPORT



Starring *12th Fail*'s Vikrant Massey, Raashii Khanna and Ridhi Dogra, this bills itself as "a riveting journey into the 2002 incident that left an indelible mark on the nation". The 'incident' at Godhra railway station led to communal riots. ***Release date: May 3***

EMERGENCY



Kangana Ranaut's labour of love, which she has also written, directed and produced, is a big-budget political drama featuring her as Indira Gandhi, with an ensemble cast. ***Release date: June 14***



"MY WHOLE INTENTION WAS THAT WHEN A FIFTH STANDARD STUDENT WATCHES IT, HE SHOULD KNOW WHATEVER HE NEEDS TO KNOW ON HOW ARTICLE 370 WAS ABROGATED"

–ADITYA JAMBHALE, *Director,* Article 370

ESCAPE FROM ESCAPISM

Film-makers like Jambhale and producers like Shah believe the audience is open to stories that break away from the escapist fantasises that Hindi cinema offers and seek to enlighten them on contemporary issues. "They are ready to come out and see something that is going to be eye-opening, conversation-worthy and makes them think," says Shah. "The young generation, exposed to world cinema, wants to engage with cinema that's powerful." Shah identifies "boldness and truthfulness" as necessary ingredients for the films to succeed. "We always knew there will be those who will say this [*The Kerala Story*] is a lie and rubbish, but [we knew] the audience will connect if they felt the film is absolutely true," he notes. Shah's opinion was validated when nine months after its theatrical release in May 2023, the film made a stir again... this time on ZEE5, when the streaming platform announced that it had crossed "150 million watch minutes within its launch weekend" and was also the highest viewed Hindi film in the southern region.

Emboldened by the response to *The Kerala Story*, Shah looks to push the